A PRACTICAL GUIDE

PREPPATH
E-BOOKS

The Power of Communication

Master the Art of Speaking

A practical guide to communication and interpersonal skills, with scripts, exercises and illustrations.



CONVERSATIONS | PUBLIC SPEAKING | PRESENTATIONS | LISTENING | WORKPLACE

INSIDE THIS BOOK

Contents

Great communicators are made, not born. This book gives you the ideas, the scripts and the practice to speak with clarity and confidence, in conversations, on stage, on screen and at work.

PART	WHAT IS INSIDE	PAGE
1. Effective Conversations	Talk with ease, ask better questions, handle tough moments	4
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6. Workplace Communication	Managers, meetings, conflict, feedback, remote work	51

How to use this book

- **Read one page, try one thing.** Every chapter ends with a practice plan.
- **Say the scripts out loud.** Words feel different in your mouth than on paper.
- **Use the toolkit.** Ready-to-use phrases and a 30-day plan wait on pages 59-60.

START HERE

Before you turn the page, write down one conversation you wish had gone better. Keep it. You will revisit it in Chapter 1.

START HERE

Welcome: Your Voice Matters

Ideas do not speak for themselves. A brilliant plan explained badly gets ignored, and an average plan explained clearly gets approved. That is why communication sits at the centre of every career.



Different languages, same goal: being understood

Communication is not about sounding impressive. It is about **making sure the other person understands what you mean, and feels heard in return**. Every skill in this book serves that one goal.

THE SIX SKILLS IN THIS BOOK

1	2	3	4	5	6
Talk	Speak	Write	Present	Listen	Work

Each skill has a chapter. **Listening** gets its own chapter because it quietly powers all the others.

You are not too quiet. You are not too loud. You are practising.

REMEMBER THIS ON HARD DAYS

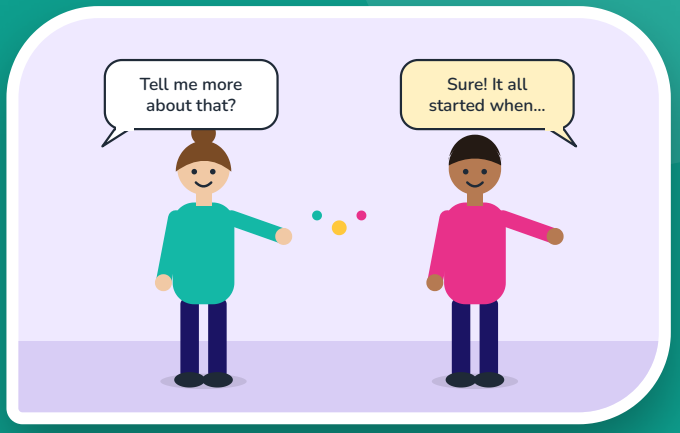
START SMALL

Confidence follows practice, never the other way round. Do small, uncomfortable things often.

CHAPTER ONE

1

Effective Conversations



Talk with ease, ask with curiosity, stay calm when it gets hard.

Conversations are where relationships begin, trust is built and problems get solved. Most of us were never taught how to hold one well. This chapter fixes that.

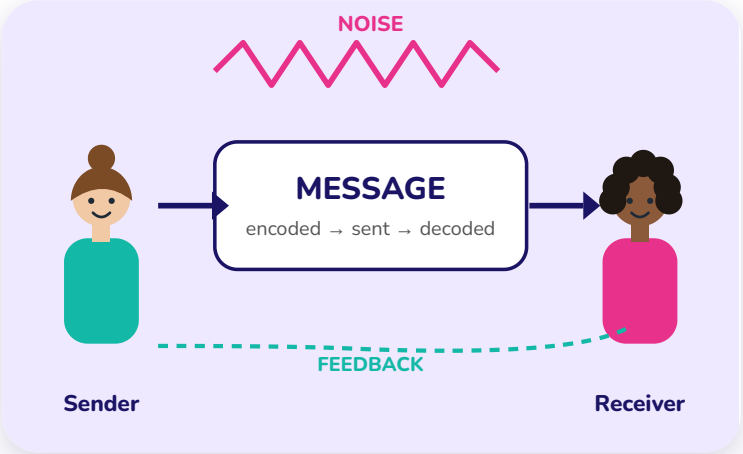
IN THIS CHAPTER

PAGE	TOPIC
5	How communication really works
6	Starting conversations and small talk
7	Asking better questions
8	Tone, pace and the power of the pause
9	Body language, myth and fact
10	Empathy in everyday talk
11	Handling difficult conversations
12	Saying no, disagreeing, apologising
13	Recap and 7-day practice plan

CHAPTER 1 · THE BASICS

How Communication Really Works

We assume that when we say something clearly, the other person receives it clearly. Rarely true. A message travels through a loop, and it can be changed at every step.



Sender encodes, receiver decodes, noise interferes, feedback closes the loop

Noise is anything that distorts the message: a loud room, a phone buzzing, stress, assumptions, even a different meaning of the same word. **Feedback** is how you find out what actually arrived.

SAME WORDS, TWO MEANINGS

ANANYA

Can you send me the file today?

VIKRAM

Sure. I will send it **later today**.

ANANYA

Later means before five, right?

VIKRAM

Oh, I meant by tonight. Let me do it by four.

CLOSE THE LOOP

When it matters, **close the loop**: “Just so we are aligned, you need the file by five. Is that right?” Ten seconds now saves a day of rework.

CHAPTER 1 · STARTING

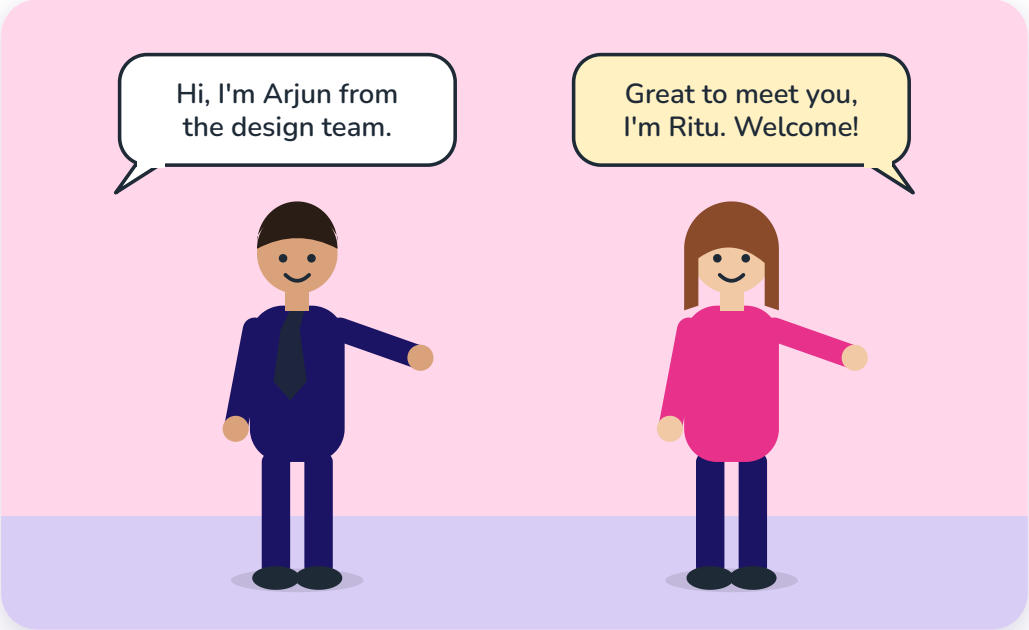
Starting Conversations and Small Talk

Small talk is not small. It is the doorway to trust. People who can open a conversation easily are rarely more talented, just more practised at the first thirty seconds.

THE FORD TOPICS

F Family & friends	**O** Occupation & work	**R** Recreation & hobbies	**D** Dreams & goals

If you ever go blank, pick one letter and ask a question about it.



A warm opener plus a name plus a question

✓ SAY THIS

"Hi, I'm Arjun. How do you know the host?"

"That session was packed. What was your favourite part?"

× NOT THIS

"So... nice weather." (then silence)

"Do you come here often?"

TRY THIS

At your next event, walk up to one person and use the pattern: **greeting + your name + an open question**. Then listen for one detail to ask about next.

CHAPTER 1 · QUESTIONS

Asking Better Questions

The quality of a conversation depends on the quality of its questions. Closed questions get a yes or no. Open questions invite a story.

CLOSED (STOPS THE FLOW)	OPEN (STARTS THE FLOW)
Did you like the project?	What did you enjoy most about the project?
Was the trip good?	What was the best moment of the trip?
Is that clear?	How would you explain it back to me?
Are you stressed?	What is taking most of your energy this week?

The follow-up is where the magic is

Most people ask one good question and then wait for their turn to talk. Instead, **follow the answer**. Repeat a key word, or say “Tell me more about that.”

FOLLOWING THE THREAD

MEERA

I started learning the violin last month.

ROHAN

Violin! What made you pick it?

MEERA

I wanted something just for me.

ROHAN

I love that. What is the hardest part so far?

WATCH OUT

Avoid “why” when you want information gently. “Why did you do that?” sounds like blame. Try “What led you to that choice?”

CHAPTER 1 · VOICE

Tone, Pace and the Power of the Pause

The same sentence can sound kind, bored or angry. What changes is not the words but the **tone, pace and volume** around them.



Your voice carries your expression. Smile and people hear it.

- **Tone:** warm and steady beats flat or sharp
- **Pace:** slightly slower than feels natural
- **Volume:** loud enough to be heard, never to dominate
- **Pause:** two beats before key points
- **Pitch:** let it rise and fall, avoid a monotone
- **Breath:** speak on the out-breath, not the gasp

✓ SAY THIS

"I hear you. (pause) Let me think about that."

× NOT THIS

"Yeah yeah, I know, but..."

THE PAUSE

A pause feels like ten seconds to you and about one to the listener. It makes you sound **thoughtful, not unsure**.

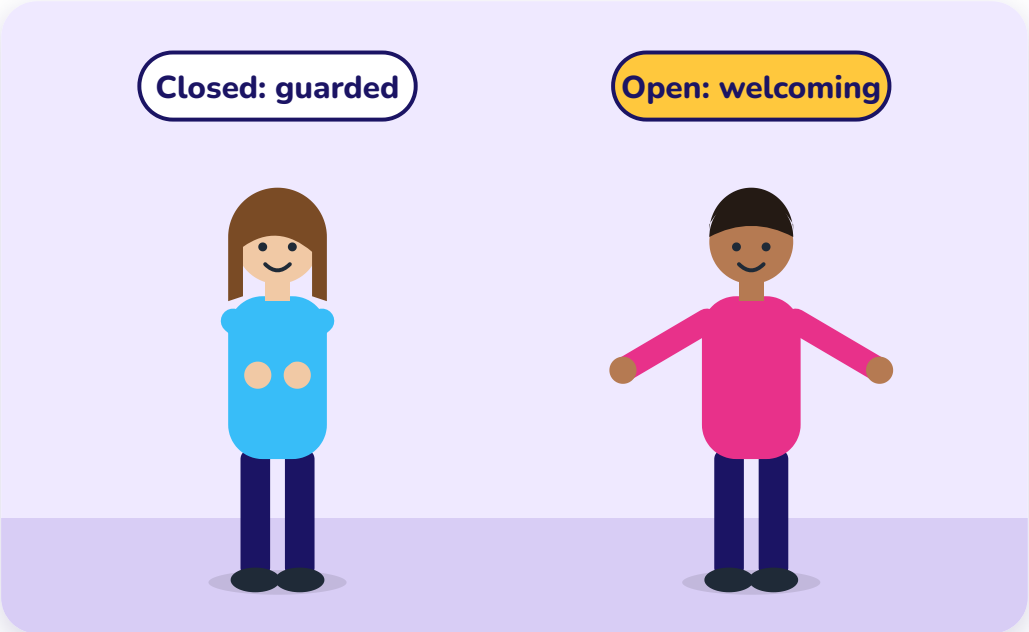
TRY THIS

Record yourself reading one paragraph at your normal speed, then again 20 percent slower. Listen to both. Which sounds more confident?

CHAPTER 1 · NON-VERBAL

Body Language: Myth and Fact

Your body speaks before your mouth does. Posture, eyes, hands and face all send messages, and listeners trust them.



Open posture invites conversation; crossed arms can read as guarded

MYTH

Only 7 percent of communication is words. The rest is tone and body language.

FACT

That number comes from tiny studies on **feelings and attitudes** when words and tone disagree. It does not mean words are unimportant when you explain a plan.

FIVE SIGNALS WORTH PRACTISING

1. **Eye contact:** 3 to 5 seconds, then look away naturally.
2. **Posture:** shoulders back, chin level, feet grounded.
3. **Hands:** visible and relaxed, not hidden or fidgeting.
4. **Face:** let your expression match your message.
5. **Space:** give people room; stand at an easy arm's length.

WATCH OUT

Do not read one signal alone. Crossed arms might mean cold, not defensive. Look for **clusters** and ask instead of assuming.

CHAPTER 1 · EMPATHY

Empathy in Everyday Talk

Empathy is understanding what someone feels and showing that you understand. It does not mean agreeing. It means the person feels seen before you try to fix anything.



Name the feeling, then respond

✓ EMPATHY

“That sounds really frustrating.”

“I can see why you are worried.”

× DISMISSING

“Don’t worry, it’s nothing.”

“At least it’s not worse.”

I

Meet Imran FICTIONAL EXAMPLE

Imran’s teammate says, “I think I failed that presentation.” Imran’s first instinct is to say “No, it was great.” Instead he says, “You sound disappointed. What felt off?” The teammate opens up and the two of them leave with a plan.

N-N-A

Use three steps: **Notice** the feeling, **Name** it gently, then **Ask** or offer help. Notice, name, ask.

CHAPTER 1 · HARD TALKS

Handling Difficult Conversations

Most of us avoid hard talks until they become harder. The skill is not avoiding them but **entering them calmly, with a plan**.

THE SBI METHOD

S
Situation: when and where

B
Behaviour: what you saw or heard

I
Impact: the effect on you or the team

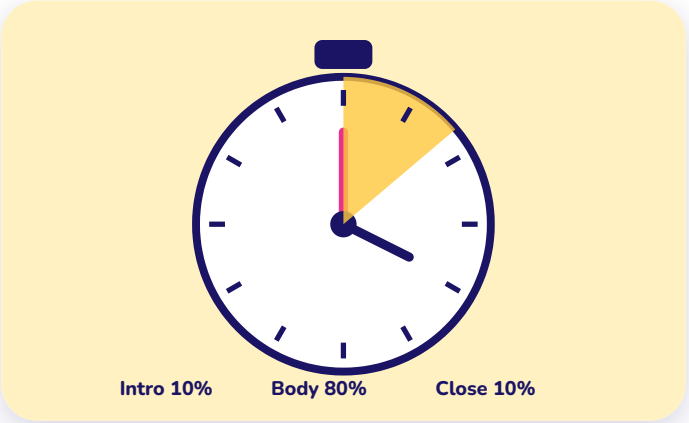
Stick to facts. Leave out labels like “irresponsible” or “selfish”.

A script you can adapt

In yesterday’s team call (situation), the update came in after the deadline (behaviour). That meant I had to rework the report overnight (impact). Can we agree on how to flag delays earlier?

BEFORE YOU START

- Pick a private place and a calm time
- Know the one outcome you want
- Open with respect, not blame
- Plan to listen at least as much as you speak



Take a ten-minute break when emotions spike

WATCH OUT

If emotions run high, say, “Let us take ten minutes and come back to this.” A pause is not defeat.

CHAPTER 1 · BOUNDARIES

Saying No, Disagreeing, Apologising

Three small skills that protect relationships: refusing without guilt, disagreeing without a fight, and apologising without excuses.



Disagreement is fine. Interrupting each other is not.

SKILL	A GOOD SCRIPT
Say no	“Thanks for thinking of me. I can’t take that on this week. I could help on Friday.”
Disagree	“I see it a little differently. Can I share another view?”
Apologise	“I’m sorry I missed the deadline. Here is what I will do to fix it.”

MYTH

An apology means you admit you are weak.

FACT

A clean apology (what happened, what you will do) **builds trust**. Long excuses destroy it.

THE KIND NO

Say no to the **request**, not to the person. Then offer an alternative if you can.

CHAPTER 1 · RECAP

Chapter 1 Recap and 7-Day Practice

You now have a toolkit for everyday conversations. Do not try to use everything at once. Pick one skill a day for a week.



Keep a tiny log: what I tried, how it felt

DAY	PRACTICE
1	Close the loop on one instruction
2	Start a conversation using FORD
3	Ask three open questions today
4	Pause two beats before an important answer
5	Notice body language in a meeting
6	Use “That sounds…” once
7	Revisit the conversation you wrote on page 2

MY BIGGEST WIN THIS WEEK

CHAPTER TWO

2

Public Speaking



Turn nervous energy into a clear, confident voice.

Fear of speaking in public is one of the most common fears in the world. The good news: it is also one of the most trainable. Every confident speaker you admire was once shaking at the start.

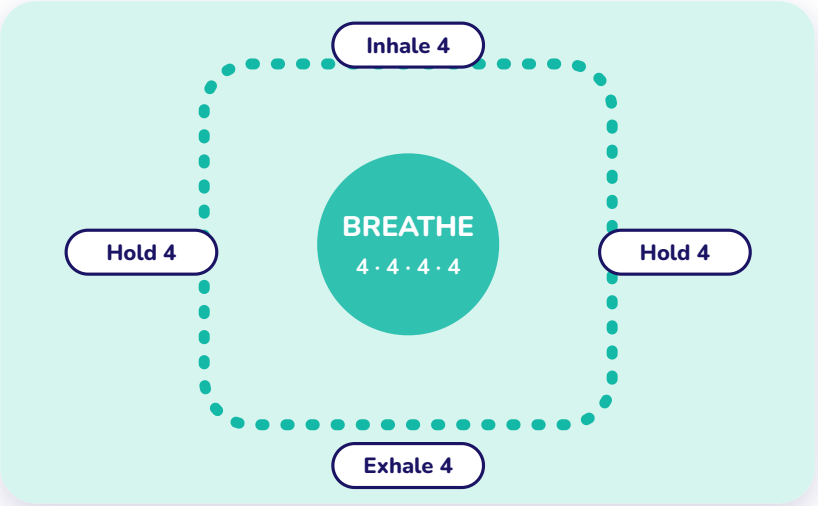
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16	Know your audience and purpose
17	Structure: beginning, middle, end
18	Openings that hook
19	Storytelling that sticks
20	Voice, gesture and stage presence
21	When things go wrong
22	Q&A and speaking on the spot
23	Recap and practice plan

CHAPTER 2 · NERVES

Fear, Nerves and Breathing

Your heart races, your palms sweat, your mouth dries. These are not signs that you will fail. They are signs that your body is **getting ready**.



Box breathing: in, hold, out, hold, four counts each

MYTH

Confident speakers do not feel nervous.

FACT

Most feel the same adrenaline. They have learned to **point it at the message** instead of at themselves.

CALM YOUR BODY IN 60 SECONDS

1. Plant both feet and relax your shoulders.
2. Breathe in through the nose for four counts.
3. Hold for four, breathe out slowly for four.
4. Repeat four times before you walk up.

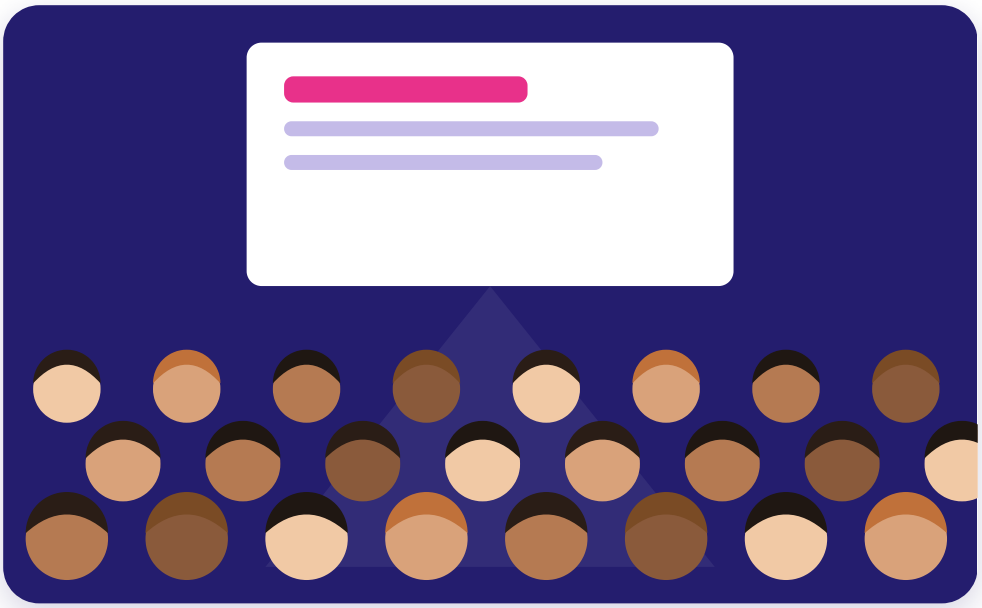
REFRAME IT

Say to yourself, “I am excited,” not “I am calm.” Nerves and excitement feel alike, and the second label gives you energy instead of fear.

CHAPTER 2 · AUDIENCE

Know Your Audience and Purpose

A talk is not about you. It is about what the audience should **know, feel or do** afterwards. Decide that first, and every other choice gets easier.



Look at the room before you write a word

THREE QUESTIONS BEFORE YOU PREPARE

1. Who is listening?
2. What do they already know?
3. What should they do next?

If you cannot answer question three in one sentence, you are not ready to write.

PURPOSE	YOUR TONE	YOUR ENDING
Inform	Clear and simple	A summary
Persuade	Confident, evidence-led	A clear ask
Inspire	Personal, warm	A memorable line

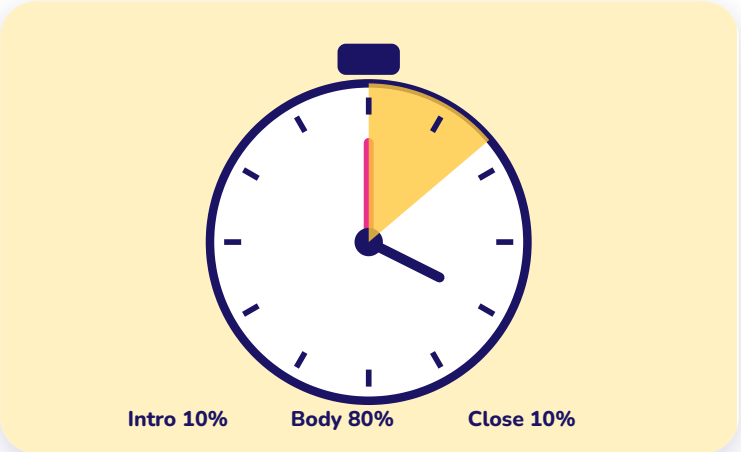
TRY THIS

Write your talk's goal as: "After this, the audience will ___." Keep it on a sticky note on your slides.

CHAPTER 2 · STRUCTURE

Structure: Beginning, Middle, End

A talk without structure feels like a road trip without a map. Audiences relax when they can see where you are going.



A simple time split: 10 percent opening, 80 percent body, 10 percent close

THE RULE OF THREE

1	2	3
Open with a hook	Make three points	Close with a call to action

Three is short enough to remember and long enough to feel complete.

SIGNPOSTS KEEP PEOPLE WITH YOU

- “I will cover three things.”
- “First… Second… Finally…”
- “That brings me to my last point.”

R

Meet Ritu FICTIONAL EXAMPLE

Ritu had to explain a new onboarding process. She tried listing ten steps and lost the room. Next time she grouped them as **Before, During and After day one**. Three buckets. The same people nodded and remembered.

CHAPTER 2 · OPENINGS

Openings That Hook

You have about **thirty seconds** to earn attention. Skip “Today I will be talking about…” and start with something that makes people lean in.

OPENING TYPE	EXAMPLE
Question	“When did you last say something and feel completely misunderstood?”
Story	“Last Tuesday, my manager asked me one question I could not answer.”
Surprising fact	“Most meetings run over time, yet most of us never ask why.”
Bold promise	“In five minutes you will have a way to open any talk.”

✓ SAY THIS

“Imagine you have two minutes to save a project…”

× NOT THIS

“Um, so, hi, today I will, like, talk about project management.”

WATCH OUT

Do not start with an apology: “Sorry, I am not good at this.” It tells the audience to doubt you.

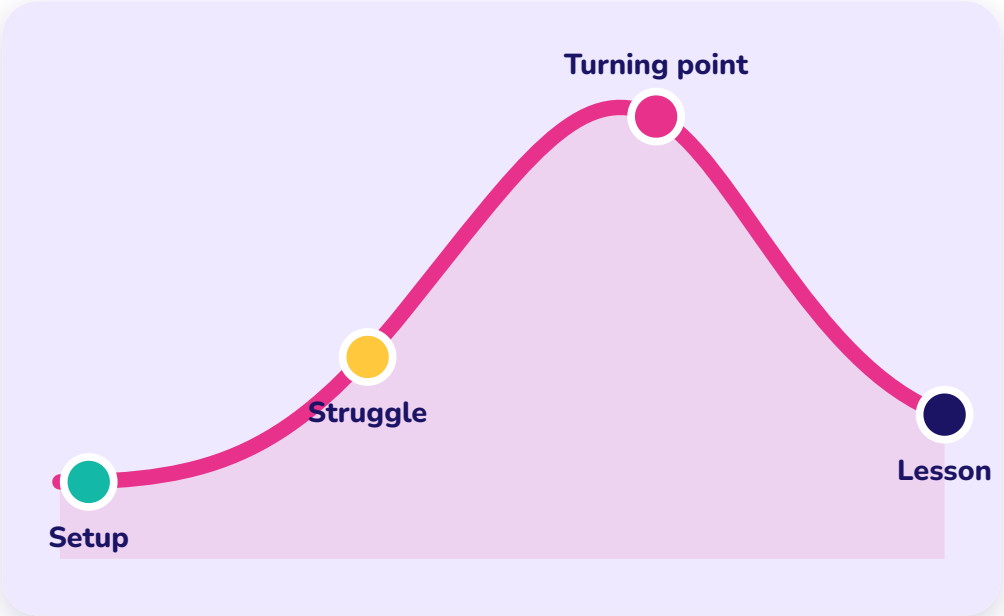
TRY THIS

Write three different openings for the same talk. Say them out loud and keep the one that makes **you** curious.

CHAPTER 2 · STORIES

Storytelling That Sticks

Facts get forgotten. Stories get repeated. A good story gives your message a face, an emotion and a reason to be remembered.



The simple story arc: setup, struggle, turning point, lesson

TWO WAYS TO SAY IT

FACT

Customer complaints fell by 18 percent.

STORY

A customer called us angry on Monday. By Friday she sent a thank-you note. Here is what changed.

- **Keep it short:** under two minutes in most talks
- **One character, one problem**
- **Real details:** a name, a place, a number
- **End with the lesson**, not a lecture

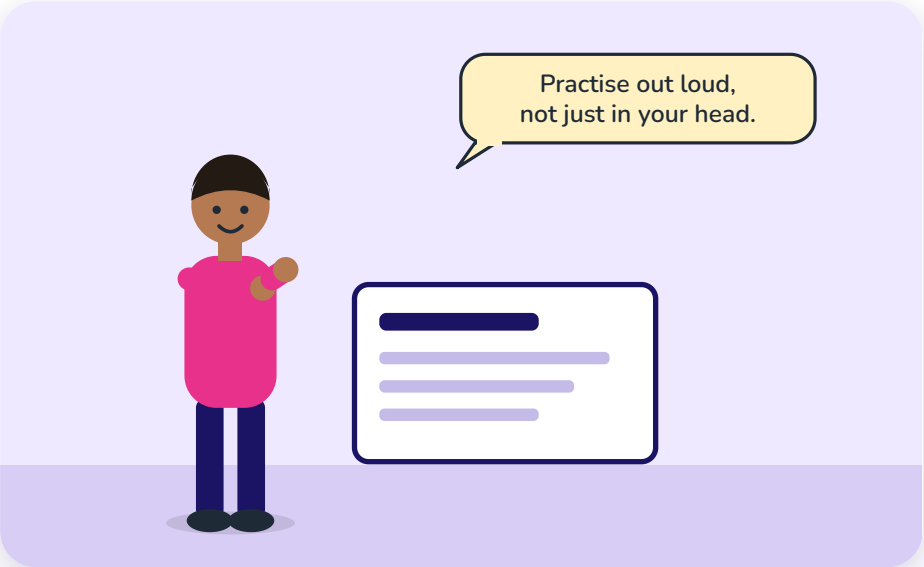
STORY BANK

Collect small moments in a notes app: something funny, hard or surprising from your week. That is your story bank.

CHAPTER 2 · DELIVERY

Voice, Gesture and Stage Presence

Presence is not a personality. It is a set of habits you can learn: where you stand, how you breathe, how you use your voice and hands.



Practise out loud, on your feet, with a timer

- **Stand tall** with feet hip-width
- **Use the space** with purposeful steps
- **Gesture inside your frame:** chest to waist
- **Vary pace** to signal importance
- **Look at one person per sentence**
- **Smile** at natural moments, not constantly

✓ PURPOSEFUL

Move, then stop and make a key point.

× DISTRACTING

Pace back and forth like a caged tiger.

TRY THIS

Film a one-minute talk on your phone with the sound off. Watch for hands, feet and face. Then watch with sound.

CHAPTER 2 · RECOVERY

When Things Go Wrong

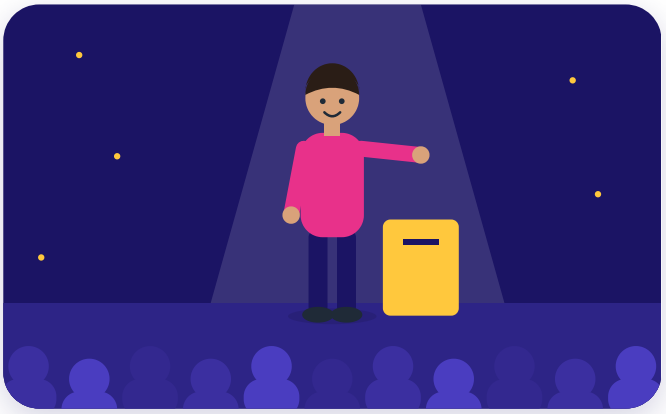
Everyone forgets a line, loses a slide or hears a phone ring in the middle of a talk. Audiences rarely notice mistakes. They notice **how you recover**.

IF THIS HAPPENS	DO THIS
You go blank	Pause, breathe, look at your notes, say the last sentence again
The tech fails	Smile, say “Let me fix this,” and keep talking without slides
Someone interrupts	“Great point. Let me finish this, then come back to you.”
You stumble on a word	Keep going. Do not apologise

V

Meet Vikram FICTIONAL EXAMPLE

Vikram’s laptop crashed two minutes into his pitch. He said, “Well, you get to hear this the old-fashioned way,” and talked through the key idea. The room laughed, relaxed, and later praised his composure.



Stay calm, keep smiling, keep going

MYTH

A mistake ruins the talk.

FACT

Calm recovery **builds credibility**. Perfection is not the goal, connection is.

BACKUP PLAN

Have one backup: a printed copy, a PDF on your phone, and a one-line summary you can say from memory.

CHAPTER 2 · Q&A

Q&A and Speaking on the Spot

Some of the hardest moments arrive without warning: a question from the back of the room, or “Could you say a few words?” A simple structure saves you.

THE PREP METHOD

P Point	**R** Reason	**E** Example	**P** Point again

Example: “I support remote Fridays (P) because focus time improves (R). Last quarter my team shipped faster on remote days (E). So I would say yes to remote Fridays (P).”

HANDLING QUESTIONS

1. **Listen** to the whole question.
2. **Repeat** or rephrase it so everyone hears.
3. **Pause**, then answer briefly.
4. **Check:** “Does that answer it?”

✓ HONEST

“Good question. I do not know yet. I will find out and email you.”

× RISKY

Guess confidently and get it wrong.

TRY THIS

Ask a friend to hand you a random topic. Speak for 60 seconds using PREP. Repeat three times with new topics.

CHAPTER 2 · RECAP

Chapter 2 Recap and Practice Plan

Public speaking is a muscle. It grows through small, regular, slightly uncomfortable reps. Here is a plan to build it.



Celebrate each speech, however small

WEEK	CHALLENGE
1	Do box breathing before three everyday conversations
2	Give a two-minute update at a meeting
3	Tell one story using the arc
4	Present a five-minute talk to friends

- [ ] I know my goal sentence
- [ ] I have one hook and one story
- [ ] I have practised out loud
- [ ] I have a backup plan

MY NEXT SPEAKING OPPORTUNITY

CHAPTER THREE

3

Professional Communication



Write, message and network with clarity and respect.

At work, your words travel without you: in emails, chats and documents. Clear professional communication saves time, avoids drama and quietly builds your reputation.

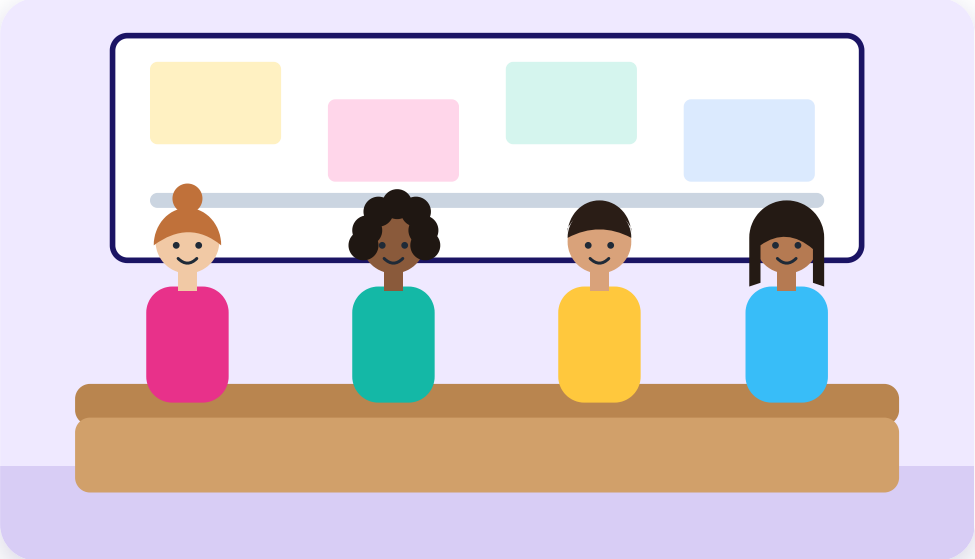
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26	Writing clear emails
27	Writing with clarity: before and after
28	Chat, phone and video etiquette
29	Networking and your 30-second pitch
30	Interview communication with STAR
31	Cross-cultural and inclusive communication
32	Recap and checklist

CHAPTER 3 · TONE

Tone, Etiquette and Professionalism

Professional does not mean cold. It means **respectful, clear and reliable**, with enough warmth that people want to work with you.



Small courtesies shape how a team feels

SITUATION	PROFESSIONAL HABIT
Greeting	Use names; match their level of formality
Reply time	Acknowledge within a day, even if the full answer takes longer
Disagreement	Criticise the idea, not the person
Credit	Name the people who helped

✓ SAY THIS

"Thanks for flagging this. I will look today."

× NOT THIS

"As I already said..."

THE TEN-MINUTE RULE

Before sending anything emotional, wait ten minutes. Read it again as if you were the receiver.

CHAPTER 3 · EMAIL

Writing Clear Emails

A good email respects the reader's time. They should know in five seconds **what it is about and what you need**.

THE BLUF EMAIL

B Bottom line first	**L** Little context	**U** Useful details	**F** Follow-up date

Bottom Line Up Front. Put the ask in the first two lines.

Template: request an update

Subject: Quick update needed on Q2 report by Thursday

Hi Priya,

Could you share the Q2 sales figures by Thursday noon? I need them for Friday's review.

The template is attached. Please fill the blue cells only.

Thank you,
Arjun

- **Subject line:** topic + action + deadline
- **One email, one main ask**
- **Short paragraphs** and bullets for lists

WATCH OUT

Avoid "Reply All" unless everyone truly needs your answer.

CHAPTER 3 · CLARITY

Writing with Clarity: Before and After

Clear writing is rewriting. Cut words that do not carry meaning, replace vague words with specific ones and put the main point first.

BEFORE	AFTER
I wanted to just reach out and touch base regarding the possibility of maybe scheduling a meeting.	Can we meet Tuesday at 3 pm to review the budget?
The deliverable is in the process of being finalised.	I will send the report by Friday.
It has been brought to my attention that there are issues.	Customers reported three login errors.



Edit once for content, once for length, once for tone

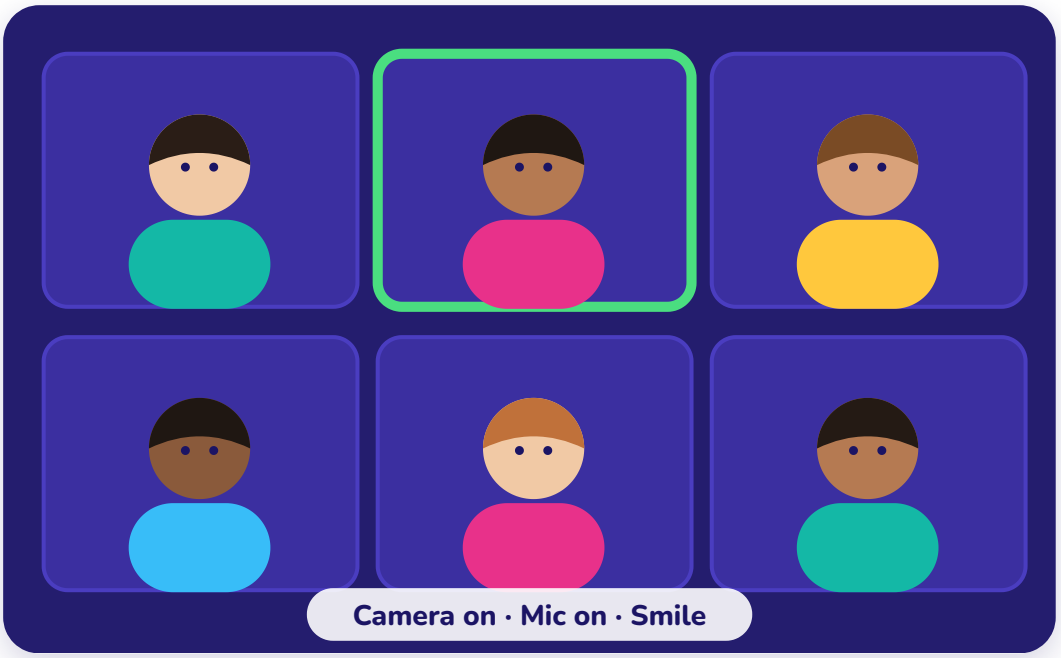
QUICK EDIT CHECKLIST

- [ ] Is the main point in the first sentence?
- [ ] Can I delete 20 percent of the words?
- [ ] Did I replace “soon” with a date?
- [ ] Would a new joiner understand every term?

CHAPTER 3 · CHANNELS

Chat, Phone and Video Etiquette

Each channel has its own rules. Chat is quick but easily misread. Calls carry emotion. Video adds eye contact and the background behind you.



Camera on, mic muted when not speaking, look at the lens

CHANNEL	BEST FOR	AVOID
Chat	Quick questions	Sensitive feedback
Phone	Urgent or emotional topics	Calling without a heads-up
Video	Discussions, relationships	Multitasking on screen

TONE IN CHAT

In chat, use full sentences and a friendly emoji or greeting. “ok.” can feel cold; “Sure, will do!” feels warm.

CHAPTER 3 · NETWORKING

Networking and Your 30-Second Pitch

Networking is not collecting business cards. It is **building small, honest relationships** with people before you need anything.

THE 30-SECOND PITCH

1	2	3
Who I am	What I do or study	What I am curious about

Example: “I am Ananya, a final-year IT student who loves building web apps. I am curious about how teams ship software quickly.”



Introduce yourself, then ask about them

AFTER THE CONVERSATION

1. Send a short note within 24 hours.
2. Mention something specific you discussed.
3. Offer help or share a useful link.
4. Stay in touch lightly: one message every few months.

TRY THIS

Write your own 30-second pitch and say it aloud twice. Edit until it sounds like you, not a brochure.

CHAPTER 3 · INTERVIEWS

Interview Communication with STAR

Interviewers do not just check answers. They watch how you think and communicate. The STAR method keeps stories tight and convincing.

STAR

S	T	A	R
Situation	Task	Action	Result

Spend most of your time on **Action** and **Result**.



Calm voice, clear structure, honest examples

INTERVIEWER

Tell me about a time you handled a tight deadline.

CANDIDATE

Our project demo was moved up by a week (S). I had to finish the login module (T). I split it into daily goals and asked a friend to review (A). We demoed on time and the faculty praised the design (R).

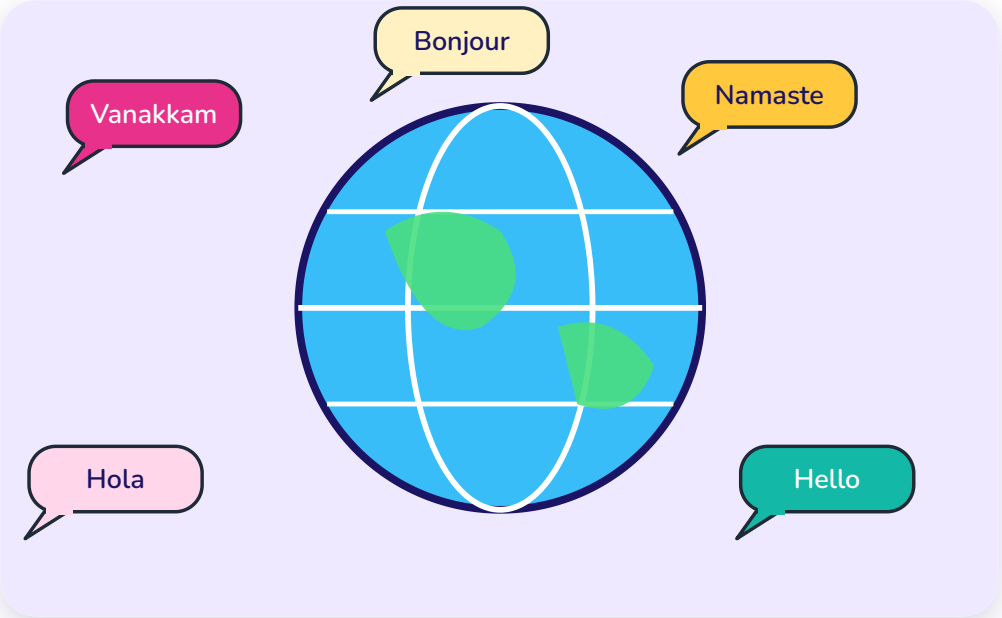
STORY BANK

Prepare four STAR stories: teamwork, a challenge, a mistake you learned from, and a time you led.

CHAPTER 3 · CULTURES

Cross-Cultural and Inclusive Communication

Modern workplaces are diverse. The same gesture, joke or phrase can mean different things in different places. Curiosity and humility go a long way.



Greetings change; respect is universal

AREA	BE AWARE
Directness	Some cultures prefer direct answers, others hint politely
Time	“Soon” and “on time” mean different things
Eye contact	Respectful in some places, rude in others
Language	Avoid slang and idioms with non-native speakers

✓ CURIOUS

“Could you say more about how this is usually done in your team?”

× JUDGING

“That is a strange way to do it.”

INCLUSIVE HABIT

Speak a little slower, use plain words and summarise in writing after meetings. That helps everyone.

CHAPTER 3 · RECAP

Chapter 3 Recap and Checklist

Professional communication is a collection of small, repeatable habits. Use this checklist before you hit send, speak up or walk into a room.

- [ ] My email states the ask in the first two lines
- [ ] My tone would feel fair if I were the reader
- [ ] I chose the right channel for the message
- [ ] I can introduce myself in 30 seconds
- [ ] I have four STAR stories ready
- [ ] I have avoided slang that may confuse others



Small habits build a strong professional reputation

Write so that the busiest person can still understand you.

CHAPTER 3 IN ONE LINE

ONE HABIT I WILL START THIS WEEK

CHAPTER FOUR

4

Presentation Skills



Turn ideas into slides, and slides into decisions.

A presentation is a conversation with slides as a helper, not a document read aloud. Great presenters make complex ideas feel simple and decisions feel easy.

IN THIS CHAPTER

PAGE	TOPIC
34	Find your one-sentence message
35	Slide design that supports you
36	Data and visuals that land
37	Structure: pyramid and SCQA
38	Delivering with slides
39	Virtual presentations
40	Handling questions and pushback
41	Presentation checklist and recap

CHAPTER 4 · PLANNING

Find Your One-Sentence Message

Before you open any slide software, finish this sentence: “If the audience remembers only one thing, it should be ___.” Everything else is support.



Plan on paper first, build slides second

THE PLANNING TRIO

1. Message: one sentence
2. Audience: what they care about
3. Action: what happens next

Write these three lines at the top of your plan.

WEAK MESSAGE	STRONG MESSAGE
Our sales update	Sales grew 12 percent, and two regions drive most of it
Project status	We are on track if we approve the extra server this week

TRY THIS

Pick a presentation you gave or saw recently. Write its one-sentence message. If you cannot, that is why it felt unclear.

CHAPTER 4 · DESIGN

Slide Design That Supports You

Slides should be seen in three seconds. If people are reading, they are not listening. Design for glance, not for study.



One idea per slide, large text, one visual

- **One idea** per slide
- **Headline as a sentence:** it states the point
- **Big text:** 28 pt or more
- **Two fonts** at most
- **High contrast:** dark on light or the reverse
- **White space** is your friend

MYTH

More text on a slide means a more professional deck.

FACT

Dense slides make audiences **read instead of listen**. Put detail in a handout.

✓ SLIDE THAT WORKS

"Sales grew 12 percent in Q2." (one big number)

× SLIDE THAT FAILS

Eight bullets in tiny font

RULE OF THUMB

Use the 10-20-30 spirit: few slides, a clear story, large type. Adjust it to your talk.

CHAPTER 4 · DATA

Data and Visuals That Land

Numbers alone do not persuade. A good chart answers one question at a glance and points to what matters.

YOUR GOAL	BEST CHART
Compare categories	Bar chart
Show change over time	Line chart
Show parts of a whole	Stacked bar or simple pie (few slices)
Show a relationship	Scatter plot

MAKE A CHART SPEAK

1. Title the chart with the **takeaway**, not the label.
2. Highlight the one bar or line that matters.
3. Remove gridlines, extra colours and 3D effects.
4. Label values directly when you can.

✓ SAY THIS

"Support tickets fell by a third after the update."

× NOT THIS

"As you can see in this chart..." (and nothing else)

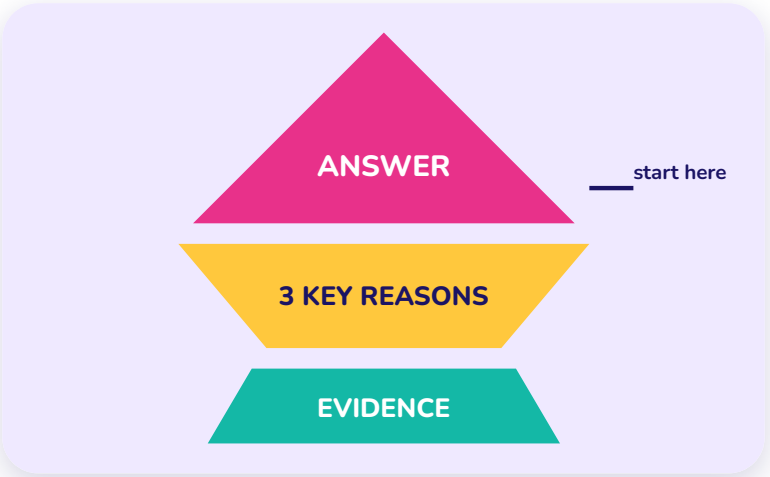
WATCH OUT

Never start the y-axis in the middle to make a small change look big. It costs you trust.

CHAPTER 4 · STRUCTURE

Structure: Pyramid and SCQA

Senior audiences want the answer first, then the reasons. This is called the **pyramid principle**: start at the top, support below.



Answer first, three supports, then evidence

SCQA STORY OPENER

S	C	Q	A
Situation	Complication	Question	Answer

"Our app has 10,000 users (S). Crashes doubled last month (C). How do we stop losing them? (Q) Fix the payment bug first (A)."



Plan on paper before you open the software

WHICH TO USE

Use the pyramid for decisions and reports, and SCQA for openings. Use stories for inspiring talks.

CHAPTER 4 · DELIVERY

Delivering with Slides

The slides are the backup singers. **You** are the lead. Face the audience, speak to people, and use the slide to support the point.

THE RIGHT RHYTHM

PRESENTER

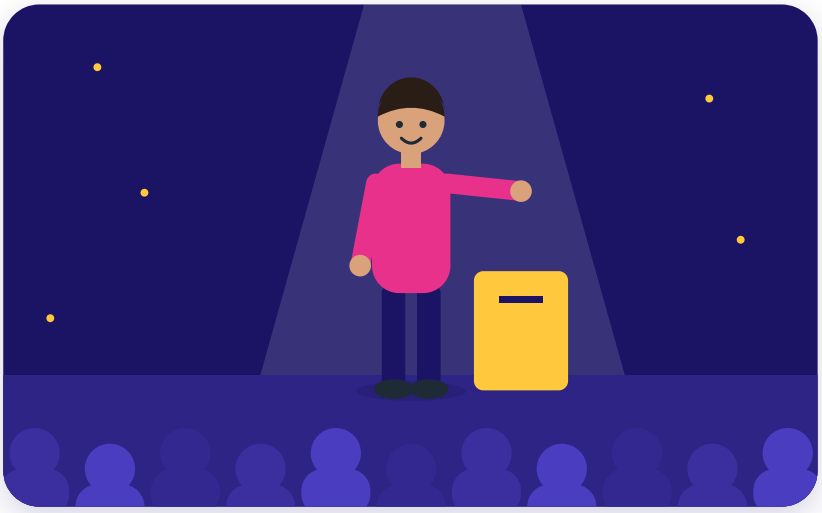
This number is the whole story. Revenue up twelve percent.

AUDIENCE

(looks at the slide for two seconds, then back at you)

DELIVERY HABITS

1. **Click, then talk.** Let the slide appear, then say your point.
2. **Pause on key slides.** Silence lets it sink in.
3. **Face the audience.** Glance at the screen, not read from it.
4. **Point with purpose.** Use hands or a pointer sparingly.



Stand beside the screen, not in front of it

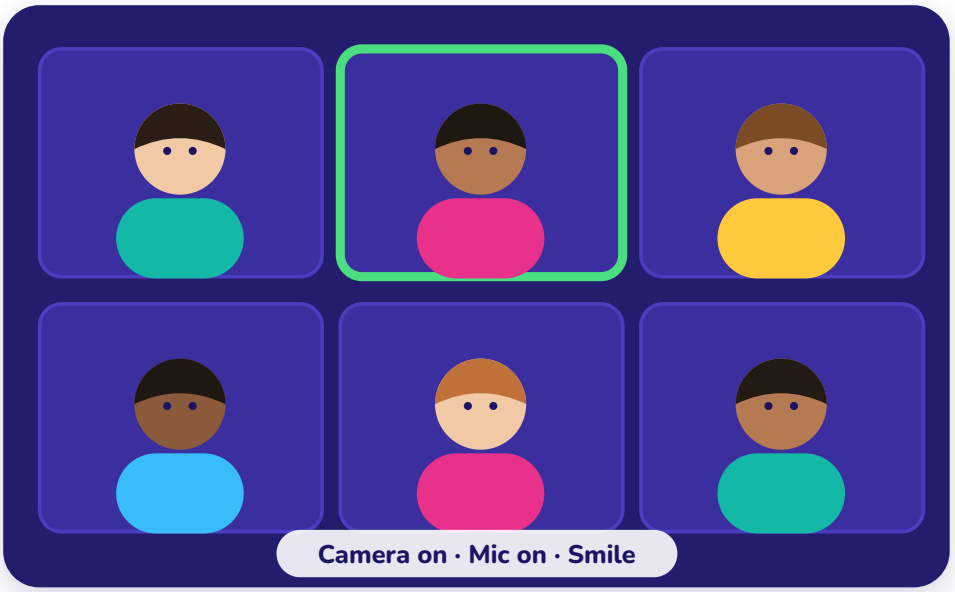
TRY THIS

Practise a three-minute talk standing, with your slides on, twice. The second time, speak without reading a single slide word.

CHAPTER 4 · ONLINE

Virtual Presentations

Online, you compete with email, chat and a sofa. Keep it shorter, more visual and more interactive than an in-person talk.



Camera at eye level, soft light in front of you

- Test sound, camera and screen share 10 minutes early
- Close extra tabs and silence notifications
- Look at the camera when making key points
- Ask a question or poll every five to seven minutes
- Share a one-page summary after

✓ ENGAGE

"Please type one word in the chat: what is your biggest challenge?"

× LOSE THEM

Twenty minutes of monologue

BACKUP

Keep a printed copy of your talking points beside the screen. It rescues you if the screen share fails.

CHAPTER 4 · QUESTIONS

Handling Questions and Pushback

Questions are a gift: they show what the audience cares about. Pushback is a sign someone is thinking, not attacking.

THE LAR RESPONSE

L	A	R
Listen fully	Acknowledge	Respond briefly

"That is a fair concern (A). Here is how we plan to handle it (R)."

CALM PUSHBACK

MANAGER

Why not wait until next quarter?

YOU

Good question. Waiting costs us two weeks of revenue. Here are the numbers.

MANAGER

And the risk?

YOU

Low. We can roll back in an hour.

TOUGH MOMENT	TRY SAYING
You do not know	"I will find out and reply by tomorrow."
Hostile tone	"I hear the frustration. Let me address the main point."
Off-topic	"Great topic. Can we take it offline after the session?"

CHAPTER 4 · RECAP

Presentation Checklist and Recap

Great presentations are prepared, not improvised. Use this checklist the day before.

- [ ] My one-sentence message is written
- [ ] Every slide has one idea and a headline sentence
- [ ] Charts have a takeaway title
- [ ] I know my opening, my three points and my close
- [ ] I have rehearsed out loud twice
- [ ] My backup plan is ready



Prepared presenters feel calm and look confident

Slides show. You tell. The audience decides.

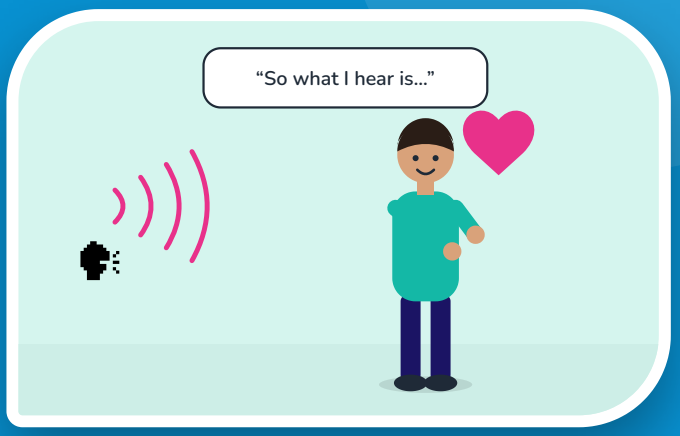
PRESENTING IN THREE WORDS

WHAT I WILL DO DIFFERENTLY NEXT TIME

CHAPTER FIVE

5

Listening and Understanding



Hear what people mean, not just what they say.

Most people listen to reply, not to understand. Real listening is rare, which is why people remember and trust those who do it well.

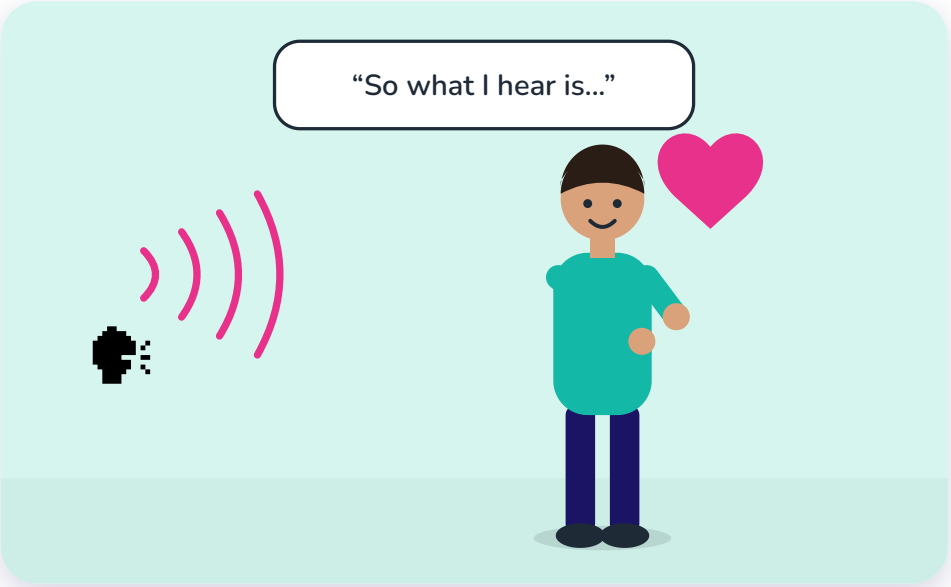
IN THIS CHAPTER

PAGE	TOPIC
43	Hearing versus listening
44	Active listening techniques
45	Barriers to good listening
46	Empathic listening
47	Clarifying questions and assumptions
48	Listening in meetings and online
49	Receiving feedback well
50	Exercises and recap

CHAPTER 5 · BASICS

Hearing Versus Listening

Hearing is automatic. Listening is a choice. It takes attention, effort and a willingness to be changed by what you hear.



Listening means paying attention to words, tone and feelings

LEVEL	WHAT IT SOUNDS LIKE
Ignoring	Scrolling the phone while they talk
Pretending	“Uh-huh, yeah” without taking it in
Selective	Hearing only what interests you
Attentive	Following the words and the message
Empathic	Understanding the feeling underneath

WHERE TO AIM

Aim for level four or five in the conversations that matter most: with your manager, family and close friends.

CHAPTER 5 · ACTIVE

Active Listening Techniques

Active listening means showing, by what you do, that you are following. Five simple techniques cover most situations.

THE FIVE MOVES

1	2	3	4	5
Face them	Nod, small sounds	Paraphrase	Ask follow-ups	Summarise

PARAPHRASE, THEN ASK

NEHA

I am swamped with the audit and the client demo.

KARAN

So two big deadlines are colliding?

NEHA

Exactly. And I cannot say no to either.

KARAN

Which one is flexible, if either?

✓ SAY THIS

"So what I am hearing is..."

"Let me check I understood..."

× NOT THIS

"Yes, yes, I know." (while looking away)

TRY THIS In your next conversation, paraphrase once before giving any opinion.

CHAPTER 5 · BARRIERS

Barriers to Good Listening

We are not bad listeners on purpose. Distractions inside and outside our minds get in the way.

BARRIER	FIX
Phone and notifications	Put it face-down or away
Planning your reply	Wait two seconds after they finish
Judging early	Stay curious until they finish
Fatigue and hunger	Pick better times for important talks
Assumptions	Ask, do not guess



When you interrupt, the other person stops sharing

WATCH OUT

Interrupting to “help” finish someone’s sentence usually backfires. Let them finish, even if it takes longer.

TRY THIS

In one conversation today, count to two after they stop talking before you speak.

CHAPTER 5 · EMPATHY

Empathic Listening

Sometimes people do not want advice. They want to be understood. Empathic listening attends to the emotion behind the words.



Listen for the feeling beneath the facts

R

Meet Ritu FICTIONAL EXAMPLE

A colleague said, “I do not think I belong on this team.” Ritu resisted the urge to say “Of course you do.” She asked, “What has been making you feel that way?” and listened for ten minutes. It was the first time he had said it aloud.

✓ ASK FIRST

“That sounds heavy. Do you want ideas, or do you want me to just listen?”

× FIX TOO FAST

“Here is what you should do.” (before they finish)

ONE QUESTION

Ask, “Do you want advice or a listening ear?” It respects them and saves time.

CHAPTER 5 · CLARITY

Clarifying Questions and Assumptions

Misunderstandings usually start with an assumption. One good clarifying question can save a week of wasted work.

INSTEAD OF ASSUMING	ASK
“She wants it quickly.”	“By when would be useful for you?”
“He is upset with me.”	“I sensed some tension. Is something on your mind?”
“Everyone knows what we mean.”	“Can you tell me what success looks like?”

TURNING VAGUE INTO CLEAR

MANAGER

Please make the report better.

YOU

Better in which way: shorter, more data, or clearer visuals?

MANAGER

Shorter, and one chart on page one.

YOU

Got it. Draft by Thursday.

THREE CLARIFYING OPENERS

1. What do you mean by ___?
2. Can you give an example?
3. What would a great result look like?

CHAPTER 5 · MEETINGS

Listening in Meetings and Online

Meetings are where listening gets hard: screens, side chats and long agendas. A few habits keep you present and useful.



Three columns: facts, feelings, follow-ups

- **Note decisions and owners**
- **Write questions, do not interrupt**
- **Mute notifications**
- **Camera on** when possible
- **Nod** so speakers see you
- **Summarise** at the end

TOOL	HOW TO USE IT
Notes	Write only decisions, actions, names, dates
Chat	Add links and questions without cutting in
Recap	“To confirm, I will send the draft by Friday.”

CLOSE THE LOOP

Say the action item out loud before the meeting ends. It turns notes into commitments.

CHAPTER 5 · FEEDBACK

Receiving Feedback Well

Feedback stings because it touches our identity. The best learners treat it as free information rather than a verdict.



Listen first, thank them, decide later

1. **Breathe** and stay quiet until they finish.
2. **Thank them:** “Thanks for telling me.”
3. **Clarify:** “Can you give an example?”
4. **Decide later:** take a day if needed.
5. **Follow up:** show what you changed.

✓ GROWTH

“That is helpful. Can I try that next week and check back?”

× DEFENSIVE

“That is not true. You do not understand my job.”

WATCH OUT

Do not defend or explain right away. The urge to justify is natural, and it ends the conversation.

CHAPTER 5 · RECAP

Chapter 5 Exercises and Recap

Listening improves with practice, like any skill. Try these exercises with a friend or colleague.

EXERCISE 1 — **Two-minute listen:** a partner speaks for two minutes while you only listen. Then summarise in three sentences. Ask, “Did I get it right?”

EXERCISE 2 — **Phone-down hour:** for one hour of conversation, keep your phone out of sight. Notice what changes.

EXERCISE 3 — **Echo and ask:** in three chats today, repeat their last few words as a question, then wait.



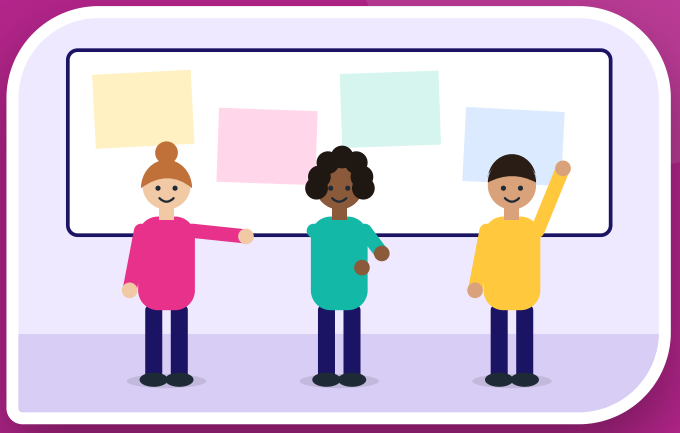
Listening is a gift that costs nothing

ONE PERSON I WILL LISTEN TO BETTER

CHAPTER SIX

6

Workplace Communication



Work together clearly, calmly and with influence.

Talent gets you hired. Communication gets you promoted. At work, how you talk to your manager, team and stakeholders decides how far your ideas travel.

IN THIS CHAPTER

PAGE	TOPIC
52	Communicating with your manager
53	Team communication and trust
54	Running and joining meetings
55	Resolving conflict
56	Giving feedback
57	Influencing without authority
58	Remote and asynchronous work
59	Your toolkit: 20 useful phrases
60	30-day plan and next steps

CHAPTER 6 · MANAGER

Communicating with Your Manager

Your manager is busy and cannot read your mind. The easiest way to be seen as reliable is to **make their job easier**: share progress, flag risks early and bring solutions.



Short, regular updates build trust

THE WEEKLY UPDATE

W	N	B
What I finished	What is next	Blockers or help needed

Send it every Friday. Three bullets are enough.

✓ **BRING SOLUTIONS**

"I am behind on X. Here are two options. I recommend option one."

× **HIDE PROBLEMS**

"Everything is fine." (until the deadline)

ONE QUESTION

Ask early: "What does great work look like for you here?" It clarifies expectations before you start.

CHAPTER 6 · TEAM

Team Communication and Trust

Teams run on trust, and trust runs on small signals: replying, keeping promises and sharing information early.



Clear owners, clear dates, shared board

HABIT	WHY IT MATTERS
Share context	People decide better with the full picture
Write it down	Decisions survive memory
Say thanks	Recognition fuels effort
Own mistakes quickly	It keeps small errors small

V

Meet Vikram FICTIONAL EXAMPLE

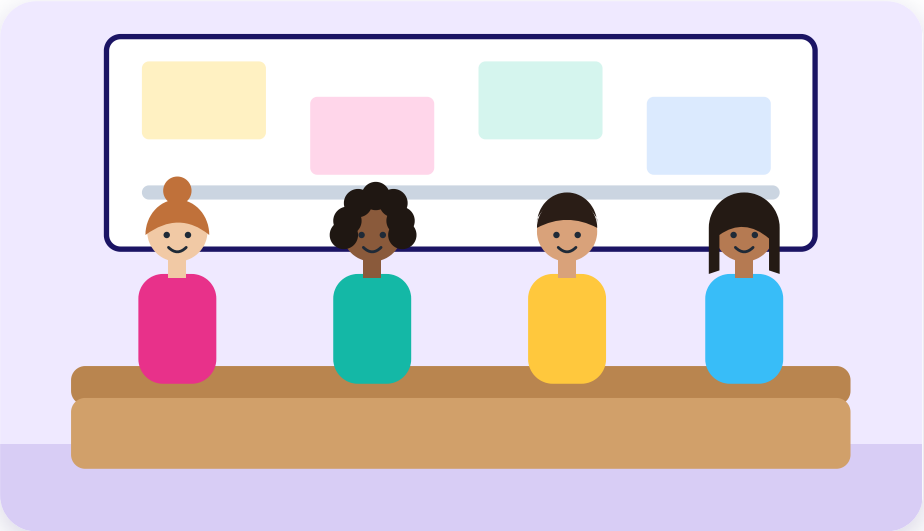
Vikram started ending each stand-up with “Anything blocking anyone?” In a month, hidden issues surfaced early and the team shipped two days sooner.

TRY THIS Ask a teammate: “What is one thing I could do to make your work easier?”

CHAPTER 6 · MEETINGS

Running and Joining Meetings

Meetings are expensive. Ten people for an hour is ten hours of work. Make each one worth it.



A purpose, an agenda and an owner

THE MEETING CHECKLIST

P	A	O
Purpose	Agenda	Owner for each action

If you cannot state the purpose in one sentence, send an email instead.

- [ ] Share the agenda a day before
- [ ] Start and end on time
- [ ] Invite only people who need to decide or act
- [ ] End with decisions, owners and dates
- [ ] Send notes within 24 hours

✓ SAY THIS

"To recap: Priya owns the draft by Wednesday."

× NOT THIS

"Let us circle back sometime."

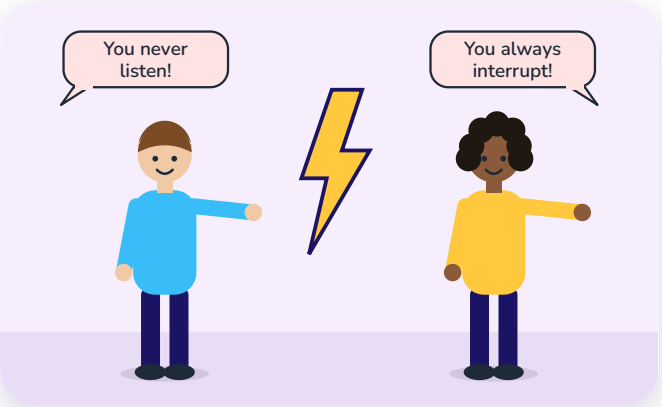
OWN YOUR TIME

If you are invited and unsure why, politely ask for the purpose and agenda.

CHAPTER 6 · CONFLICT

Resolving Conflict

Conflict is normal wherever people care. Handled badly, it breeds resentment. Handled well, it produces better ideas.



Separate the person from the problem

THE CALM CONVERSATION

1. Cool down first
2. Listen to their view
3. Share yours using I-statements
4. Agree on a next step

✓ I-STATEMENT

"I feel stuck when plans change late. Can we agree a cut-off?"

× YOU-ATTACK

"You always change things at the last minute."

A CONVERSATION THAT WORKS

ARJUN

I felt unheard in the review. Can we talk?

RITU

Sure. I did not realise. Tell me what happened.

ARJUN

I suggested the new flow and it was skipped.

RITU

Thanks for saying so. Let us look at it together.

CHAPTER 6 · FEEDBACK

Giving Feedback That Helps

Good feedback is specific, timely and kind. It helps the person improve and shows that you care about their success.



Specific, timely, kind

VAGUE	SPECIFIC
“Good job.”	“Your summary slide made the decision easy for the client.”
“You are careless.”	“Three numbers in the report did not match the source. Let us add a check.”

THE FEEDBACK SANDWICH, UPGRADED

1. What worked
2. What to change (SBI)
3. How I can help

ASK PERMISSION

Ask first: “Would you like some feedback on that?” People hear it better when they have agreed to it.

CHAPTER 6 · INFLUENCE

Influencing Without Authority

You do not need a title to lead. Influence comes from credibility, relationships and a clear case that serves other people's goals.



Lead with the answer, back it with evidence

1. **Build credibility** by delivering small promises.
2. **Understand their goals** before you pitch.
3. **Make it easy to say yes** with a short, clear ask.
4. **Use evidence and stories**, not pressure.
5. **Thank and share credit** when it works.

✓ INVITE

"This could save your team about three hours a week. Can we try it for two weeks?"

× PUSH

"You must do this my way."

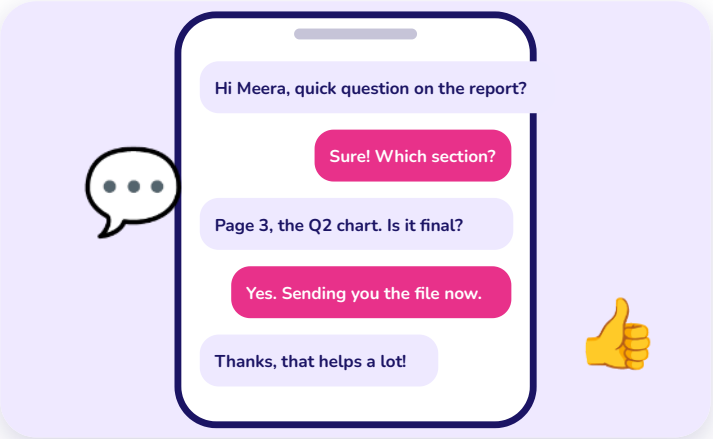
TRY THIS

Pick one improvement you want. Write the one-sentence ask, the benefit for them and a low-risk way to test it.

CHAPTER 6 · REMOTE

Remote and Asynchronous Work

When people work across cities and time zones, writing becomes the main language of the team. Clear, complete messages are your superpower.



Write messages that need no follow-up

Template: async update

Hi team,

Context: Login bug affects 3 percent of users.
Status: Fix ready; testing today.
Decision needed: Release tonight or tomorrow?
Please reply by 5 pm IST.

Thanks,
Meera

- State the decision and the deadline
- Share links, not screenshots of text
- Mention time zones clearly
- Summarise long threads
- Celebrate wins in public

VISIBILITY

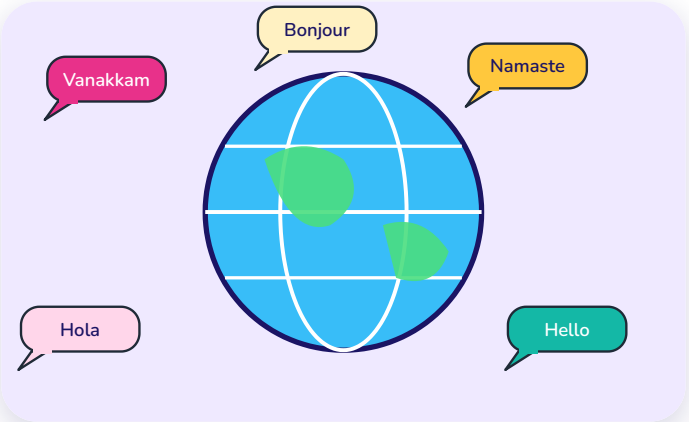
Overcommunicate a little. Remote teammates cannot see your effort unless you share it.

TOOLKIT

Your Toolkit: 20 Useful Phrases

Keep these in a notes app and adapt them to your voice. A good phrase on hand is worth a minute of panic.

SITUATION	PHRASE
Buying time	“Let me think and get back to you by tomorrow.”
Clarifying	“Just to be sure I have this right…”
Disagreeing	“I see it differently. Can I share why?”
Saying no	“I cannot take that on now. I can help next week.”
Asking for help	“I have tried X and Y. Could you point me the right way?”
Interrupted	“One moment, I will finish this thought.”
Giving credit	“This was Priya’s idea, and it worked.”
Apologising	“Sorry about that. Here is how I will fix it.”
Calming	“Let us take five minutes and come back to this.”
Ending a call	“Thanks for your time. I will send a summary today.”



Different words, same goal: understanding

30-DAY PLAN

Your 30-Day Communication Plan

Pick one habit per week. Small, steady practice beats big, rare effort.

WEEK	FOCUS	DAILY ACTION
1	Listening	Paraphrase once per conversation
2	Speaking	Open every answer with the point first
3	Writing	Edit each email once for length
4	Presenting	Give one two-minute talk



You have the tools. Now practise.

- [ ] I have chosen my week-one habit
- [ ] I have told a friend to hold me accountable
- [ ] I have saved the toolkit phrases

Speak clearly. Listen deeply. Repeat daily.

THE WHOLE BOOK IN ONE LINE

Keep learning with PrepPath

Explore more e-books on career, technology and personal growth. Visit our website and shop now: **preppath-ebooks-store.vercel.app**